IOWN

# The Morning Brief

APRIL 18, 2026

# Open Waters

*Weekend Edition — Iran opens the Strait, oil crashes, and the S&P 500 posts a fourth consecutive all-time high.*

| S&P 500 FRI CLOSE | BRENT CRUDE FRI CLOSE | GOLD FRI CLOSE | BITCOIN (LIVE) | FEAR & GREED |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 7,126 · 4th ATH | ~$89 · Hormuz repricing | ~$4,860 · 4th weekly gain | ~$74,700 · Near $75K | 21 · Extreme Fear |

SECTION 01

## Markets — Week in Review

### FROM 7,000 TO HORMUZ — A WEEK THAT RESHAPED THE POST-CONFLICT TRADE

The S&P 500 closed Friday at 7,126, posting its fourth consecutive all-time high after crossing 7,000 for the first time earlier in the week. Friday's session delivered the defining development: Iranian Foreign Minister Araghchi declared the Strait of Hormuz open to all commercial shipping, sending Brent crude down approximately 10% and equities to fresh records. The Nasdaq Composite extended its winning streak to 13 consecutive sessions, the longest since 1992. What began as a recovery from the March 30 conflict low has become something more: the market is now pricing a post-war equilibrium in which the energy risk premium compresses sharply and growth leadership reasserts itself.

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| S&P 500 | 7,126 · 4th consecutive all-time high |
| NASDAQ | 13-day winning streak · Longest since 1992 |
| BRENT CRUDE | ~$89 · ↓~10% Friday on Hormuz |
| GOLD | ~$4,860 · 4th consecutive weekly gain |
| CONSUMER SENTIMENT | 47.6 · 74-year record low (pre-ceasefire) |

### CONSUMER SENTIMENT AT A RECORD LOW — BUT THE DATA MAY ALREADY BE STALE

The University of Michigan's Consumer Sentiment Index fell to 47.6 in April's preliminary reading, the lowest in the survey's 74-year history, with one-year inflation expectations surging from 3.8% to 4.8%. However, 98% of respondents were interviewed before the April 8 ceasefire announcement, meaning the data captures peak war anxiety and could partially recover in the final reading. The divergence between institutional behavior and consumer despair is notable: hedge funds deployed substantial capital into equities this week while consumers reported their worst outlook on record. Kevin Warsh's Fed Chair confirmation hearing on Tuesday could become the next catalyst for rate expectations, with his financial disclosures revealing assets exceeding $135 million and the hearing facing a potential obstacle from Senator Tillis's standoff with the White House over a DOJ investigation into Chair Powell.

*Four all-time highs in a single week. The Strait declared open. Oil in retreat. Consumer sentiment at a 74-year low. The market is pricing a post-conflict world while consumers are still processing the conflict itself. That gap between institutional conviction and consumer anxiety may define the next phase — and history suggests the institutions tend to lead.* **Think Like an Owner.**

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SECTION 02

# Geopolitics

### IRAN DECLARES HORMUZ OPEN — BUT THE US BLOCKADE REMAINS

Friday produced the conflict's most consequential diplomatic development since the April 8 ceasefire. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi announced that the Strait of Hormuz is open to all commercial shipping for the duration of the Lebanon ceasefire, according to NBC News and CNBC. The announcement sent Brent crude down approximately 10% on the session. However, the picture remains fragmented: President Trump stated that the US naval blockade of Iranian ports would remain in full force until a comprehensive peace deal is reached. The contradiction creates an uncertain environment for commercial shipping and energy markets. If vessels begin transiting the Strait in volume, the war premium embedded in oil prices could continue to compress. If the US blockade continues to deter traffic despite Iran's declaration, the premium persists in a different form — one driven by enforcement risk rather than physical obstruction. For IOWN's energy sleeve, this represents the clearest signal yet that the acute phase of the energy trade is winding down, though the structural supply deficit from damaged infrastructure and Iran's halted petrochemical exports remains a medium-term tailwind for CVX, VLO, and OKE.

### PARIS SUMMIT — 49 NATIONS CHART AN INDEPENDENT COURSE ON HORMUZ

French President Macron and UK Prime Minister Starmer co-chaired an emergency summit at the Élysée Palace on Friday, attended in person by German Chancellor Merz and Italian Prime Minister Meloni, with 45 additional countries joining by videoconference, according to Bloomberg and Al Jazeera. The summit called for the unconditional, unrestricted, and immediate reopening of the Strait and proposed a Franco-British-led defensive multinational naval mission to protect merchant vessels and conduct mine clearance operations once a sustainable ceasefire is achieved. A follow-up military planning summit is scheduled at the UK's Permanent Joint Headquarters in Northwood next week. The absence of the US and Israel from the summit represents a notable moment of European strategic autonomy on energy security. If this multilateral framework produces a credible alternative to the US-led blockade, it could offer Iran a pathway to sustained Hormuz normalization independent of bilateral US terms — a development that would be structurally deflationary for global energy prices and constructive for the broader equity market.

### CEASEFIRE EXPIRES APRIL 22 — THREE TRADING DAYS

The two-week US-Iran ceasefire, mediated by Pakistan and agreed on April 8, expires on Wednesday April 22. The White House has not formally requested an extension, though press secretary Leavitt indicated that conversations remain productive and ongoing. President Trump's statement that the US may need to resume military operations if no deal materializes heightens the stakes. The Israel-Lebanon ceasefire, reached earlier this week, removed one front from the equation, but the nuclear question, Hormuz transit terms, and reparations remain unresolved. If the ceasefire extends, equity markets could consolidate at record levels with reduced tail risk. If it lapses without a framework, the recovery faces its first significant test at all-time highs. Carson's SPY $645.80 retracement target remains the active downside level, sitting approximately 9% below Friday's close — a threshold that would only come into play under a material re-escalation scenario.

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|---|---|
| HORMUZ | Iran says open · US blockade remains |
| PARIS SUMMIT | 49 nations · Franco-British naval mission proposed |
| NORTHWOOD | Military planning summit next week |
| CEASEFIRE | Expires April 22 · No formal extension |
| BRENT CRUDE | ~$89 · Sharp decline on Hormuz reopening |

SECTION 03

# On Our Radar

**1. Week Ahead: Ceasefire, Warsh, and Earnings Season Deepens.** The ceasefire expires Wednesday April 22. Kevin Warsh's Fed Chair confirmation hearing is Tuesday April 21 — the first step in the Fed's leadership transition, with Powell's term expiring May 15. Warsh's hearing faces a potential obstacle from Senator Tillis, who has refused to vote for a nominee until the DOJ drops its investigation into Powell. IOWN dividend sleeve holding GPC reports Q1 Tuesday (consensus $1.82 EPS), and Tesla reports Wednesday. The convergence of the war's diplomatic deadline and the Fed transition makes this the most watched stretch since the conflict began. *Research Reveals Opportunities.*

**2. Consumer Sentiment and the Institutional-Retail Divide.** The University of Michigan's record-low 47.6 reading and 4.8% one-year inflation expectation contrast sharply with the institutional bid visible in consecutive all-time highs and hedge fund equity accumulation. If the May final reading recovers — as the pre-ceasefire interview timing suggests it could — the market finds additional support from normalizing consumer psychology. If it does not, consumer-facing IOWN holdings (HOOD, SYF, TOL) could face headwinds even as the broader tape advances. *Avoid Erosion.*

**3. Netflix's Post-Earnings Decline Reinforces the Elevated Bar at Record Levels.** Netflix beat Q1 consensus by a wide margin ($1.23 EPS vs $0.78 estimate) but fell approximately 9% in after-hours trading after declining to raise full-year guidance and announcing co-founder Reed Hastings's departure from the board. The pattern mirrors ABT's 6% decline on a narrow miss earlier in the week: at record levels, markets tend to demand not just beats but raised outlooks. IOWN holdings entering Q1 reporting — including GPC, TEL, and SYK — face the same elevated bar. *Simplicity Over Complexity.*

**4. Digital Assets Consolidate Near a Key Psychological Level.** Bitcoin is holding near $75,000 over the weekend at approximately $74,700, with IBIT holding steady near Thursday's $42.73 close. The digital assets sleeve has recovered from the March Clarity Act selloff and is trading at multi-week highs. With the SEC's recent elimination of the pattern day trading rule providing a structural tailwind for retail trading platforms, the regulatory backdrop has shifted constructively for IOWN's digital exposure across IBIT, ETHA, COIN, HOOD, MARA, and HUT. *Think Like an Owner.*

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